HARDIK CHHABRA



KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **Editorial judgement begins with the story's relevance—why they matter now and why readers should care**
- **Magazine journalism must go beyond daily news, explain context, consequences and long-term trends**
- **Original reporting remains journalism's most valuable currency. An on-ground report is still a most compelling story**
- **Strong editorial institutions are built on debate but guided by leadership. The editor ultimately has the responsibility, and takes the final call**
- **Unlike in the past, today's power structures are leak-proof—journalists must work harder to uncover original stories**

Chawla and former *Business Standard* editor T.N. Ninan argued that readers ultimately care about the economic ripple effects, particularly an emerging energy crisis and rising fuel prices that directly affect households. Ninan framed the story in classic magazine terms: explaining how geopolitical shocks translate into consequences for citizens, markets and supply chains.

Ex-editor Kaveree Bamzai made a contrarian case for putting the blockbuster film sequel, *Dhurandhar The Revenge*, on the cover, arguing that when reality overwhelms readers, culture and cinema offer another way to understand the moment. BJP ideologue Swapan Dasgupta cautioned that in an era of podcasters and social media, the magazine must offer a surprise Indian perspective that western outlets cannot. Current editor Raj Chengappa broadened the editorial lens, suggesting multiple possible angles: an inside account from Iran, the technological transformation of warfare, the energy crunch triggered by the conflict, and the wider implications of Trump's global posture. Magazine journalism, he argued, must move beyond headline news to identify deeper trends.

It was left to Aroon Purie to deliver the final verdict. And he did it with characteristic economy: if a correspondent could get into Tehran, that was the cover because no one else could better tell the sounds, smells and human texture of a city under bombardment. Failing that, the fallback was the war's economic toll on ordinary Indians. Throughout, the editors traded anecdotes that illuminated the institutional DNA of INDIA TODAY: a culture where no expense was spared for a story, where reporters competed fiercely for assignments on merit, and where the editor-in-chief's word was final, but never immune to a better argument the next morning. ■